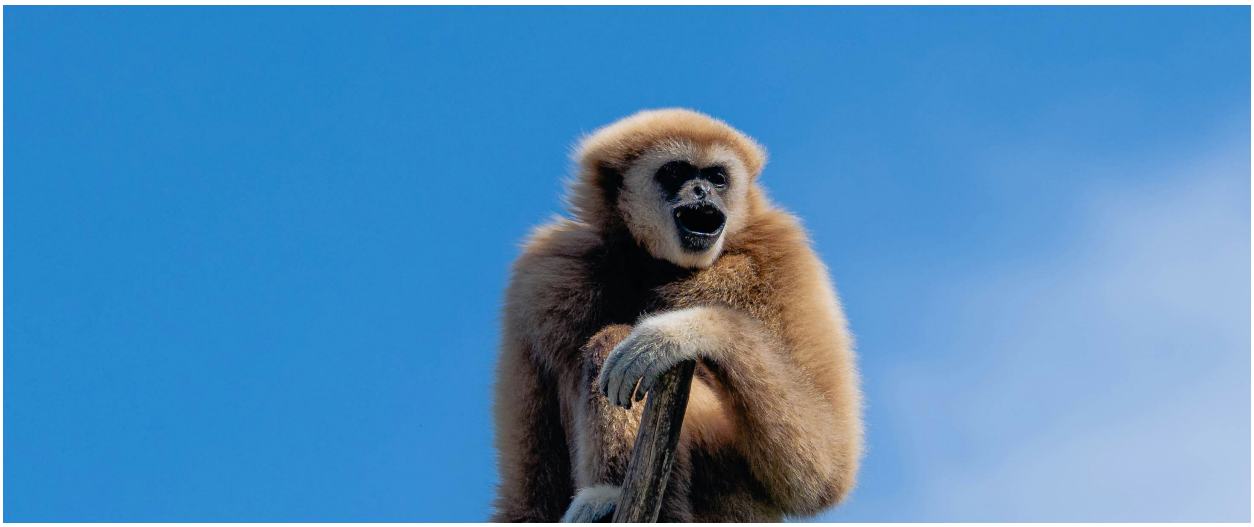


Introduction to Primates by learnandhelpanimals.com

Primates are mammals, and one thing they all have in common is their ability to grab things with their hands and feet.

Most primates are omnivores: they eat a mix of fruit, leaves, insects and sometimes small animals.

Most live in the trees and their sight is the most developed sense.

Primates can be divided into two categories:

- Wet-nosed (Strepsirrhines)
- Dry-nosed (Haplorhines)

Wet-nosed primates rely on their sense of smell and have a moist nose. They tend to be smaller and nocturnal. They also use their dental as a comb

We are talking about lemurs, lorises and galagos.

On the other hand, dry-nosed primates mainly rely on their sense of sight. This includes monkeys, apes and tarsiers.

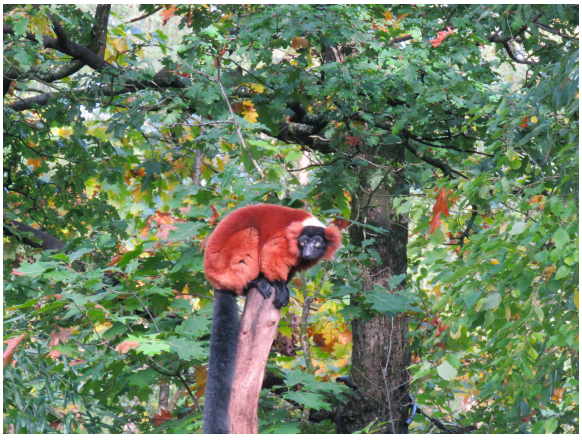
1. WET-NOSED

1. 1 Lemurs:

Belong to the Strepsirrhines, wet-nosed primates. There are different species of lemurs but they all come from Madagascar and have some common characteristics:

- They have a short fertile window. It can be one day for some, or even less.
- For ruffed lemurs, it’s common that when they give birth they have twins or triplets.
- Most lemurs are female dominated.
- Many don’t drink much water because they get most of their water from the plants they eat.

Ring tailed lemur



Crowned sifaka lemur

1. 2 Loris and galagos:

Nocturnal animals. Lorises live in Asia and Africa; galagos only in Africa.

The slow loris is the only venomous primate.

Slow loris. A cutie but venomous.

2.DRY-NOSED

To explore the division of dry-nosed primates, it’s important to first clear up some terminology.

We will talk about Anthropoids, meaning monkeys and apes, the primates that most resemble humans. The concepts of New World and Old World will also come up, meaning:

- Old World: Those coming from Africa and Asia. They have narrow noses with downward-facing nostrils.
- New World: Those coming from Central and South America. They have flat noses with sideways nostrils.

So, most dry-nosed primates are Anthropoids, with the exception of the Tarsier.

2.1 Tarsier:

Only dry-nosed primate that is not anthropoid.

They are tiny creatures, around 10–15 cm long. Each eye is as big as their brain.

Their ankle bones (tarsals) are very long, hence their name. This allows them to jump many times their body length.

They are nocturnal and the only fully carnivorous primates: eating insects, lizards and even small birds and snakes.

Among the rest, we have: Old World monkeys, New World monkeys and apes.

Tiny tarsier in the Philipines

2.2 Anthropoids

2.2.1 New World monkeys:

We have the Emperor Tamarin, Marmosets and Mandrill. These tend to be smaller monkeys and love living in the heights, up in the trees.

Emperor Tamarin, a new world very small monkey

Silvery marmoset

2.2.2 Old world monkeys:

We have the macaques and baboons. Many of these monkeys spend a lot of time on the ground.

2.2.3 Apes:

These include bonobos, chimps, orangutans, gorillas, humans and gibbons.

Bonobos and chimps are our closest relatives, with a DNA match of about 98.7%.

All apes have no tail and bigger brains relative to body size.

Apes can learn, play, have social hierarchies and are very social.

Gorillas, chimps and bonobos spend a lot of time on the ground, while orangutans and gibbons live mostly in the trees.

Orangutans are quite solitary apes.

Westland gorilla